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California, US Lawmakers Debate License Plate Reader Technology

Every day, untold numbers of Californians drive past the thousands of cameras that at least 230 police and sheriffs' departments have posted along roadways or installed on their patrol cars.

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By Ryan Sabalow, CalMatters









A Flock camera monitors the intersection at McKee Road and North White Road in San José on Apr. 2, 2026. Since 2019, California Democratic lawmakers have unsuccessfully sought to further restrict how police use the technology. (Martin do Nascimento)

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In the past year alone, they've helped catch suspected murderers, [bank robbers](#) and [hit-and-run drivers](#). They've located dozens of stolen cars and helped send a wildland arsonist to [prison](#). They're also distrusted and despised by privacy rights activists on the left and on the right. Just last month, [police accused a suspect](#) in Monterey County of yanking down three of them with his hands. They're called automated license plate readers. Every day, untold numbers of Californians drive past the thousands of cameras that at least 230 police and sheriffs' departments have posted all over the state.

The cameras in real time capture and read plate numbers, then [cross-reference](#) them with law enforcement databases of vehicles police want to locate, such as stolen cars, getaway vehicles or vehicles involved in crimes. Since 2019, California Democratic lawmakers have unsuccessfully sought to further restrict how police use the technology. They're trying again this year [with a bill](#) that would add limits on how the cameras can be used.







A Flock Safety license plate recognition camera is seen near the intersection of Marine Street and Arapahoe Avenue in Boulder on March 5, 2026. (Matthew Jonas/MediaNews Group/Boulder Daily Camera via Getty Images)

Critics of the technology cite high-profile examples of California police using license plate data inappropriately, including to stalk or harass innocent people. [As CalMatters reported last year](#), 404 Media also [reported last year](#) that a Texas cop searched a national license plate database to try to locate a woman who had an abortion, leading to fears that conservative states that criminalize abortion. Cervantes' bill would generally limit to 30 days the amount of time agencies could keep license plate data, unless it pertains to an active investigation or is part of a search for missing people. It would also prohibit police and sheriffs' departments from entering into contracts with camera companies that provide default access to plate databases that federal and out-of-state police can use. That provision is in response to Flock Safety, a prominent license plate reader company that allowed federal authorities to search local license plate data [as part of a pilot program](#), said Tracy I.







A protester holds a sign during a rally opposing Berkeley's proposed contract expansion with surveillance company Flock Safety outside the Berkeley Unified School District boardroom in Berkeley on May 7, 2026. (Gustavo Hernandez/KC

“(Police departments) learned after the fact, like our advocates did,” Rosenberg said. “And we all said, ‘What the ...’ You know, pick your four-letter word.”

Flock Safety did not respond to CalMatters’ request for an interview, but the company says on [its website](#) that it doesn’t work with immigration agencies and it stopped its federal pilot program

“By default, sharing with federal agencies is disabled,” the company wrote. “ICE does not have direct access to Flock cameras, systems or data.”

Why police are opposed

At least 39 police agencies and officers’ unions oppose [Senate Bill 1013](#). Combined, they have spent at least \$5.6 million on legislative campaigns since 2000, according to the [CalMatters Digit](#)

Tustin Police Chief Sean Thuilliez, president of the California Police Chiefs Association, said the technology helped clear an innocent man. It also identified a suspected killer when [a woman w](#)

The woman had just testified against her ex-husband in a restraining order case, making him a prime suspect, Thuilliez said.







A Berkeley Police Department squad car in Berkeley on July 30, 2025. (Martin do Nascimento/KQED)

But Thuilliez said that thanks to the city's 102 license plate readers, eight of which are from Flock, detectives quickly ruled out her ex-husband and were able to apprehend [her former boyfriend](#)

"It's technology mixed with good investigative work," he said in an interview. "But within one weekend, we were able to arrest the suspect for this person's murder."

The Berkeley Police Department noted similar successes after [52 Flock cameras](#) were installed last year. In [a report](#) to the Berkeley City Council, the department noted license plate readers ha

The department noted its rate for solving robbery cases climbed from 34% in 2024 to 49% the following year, thanks in part to the license plate data.

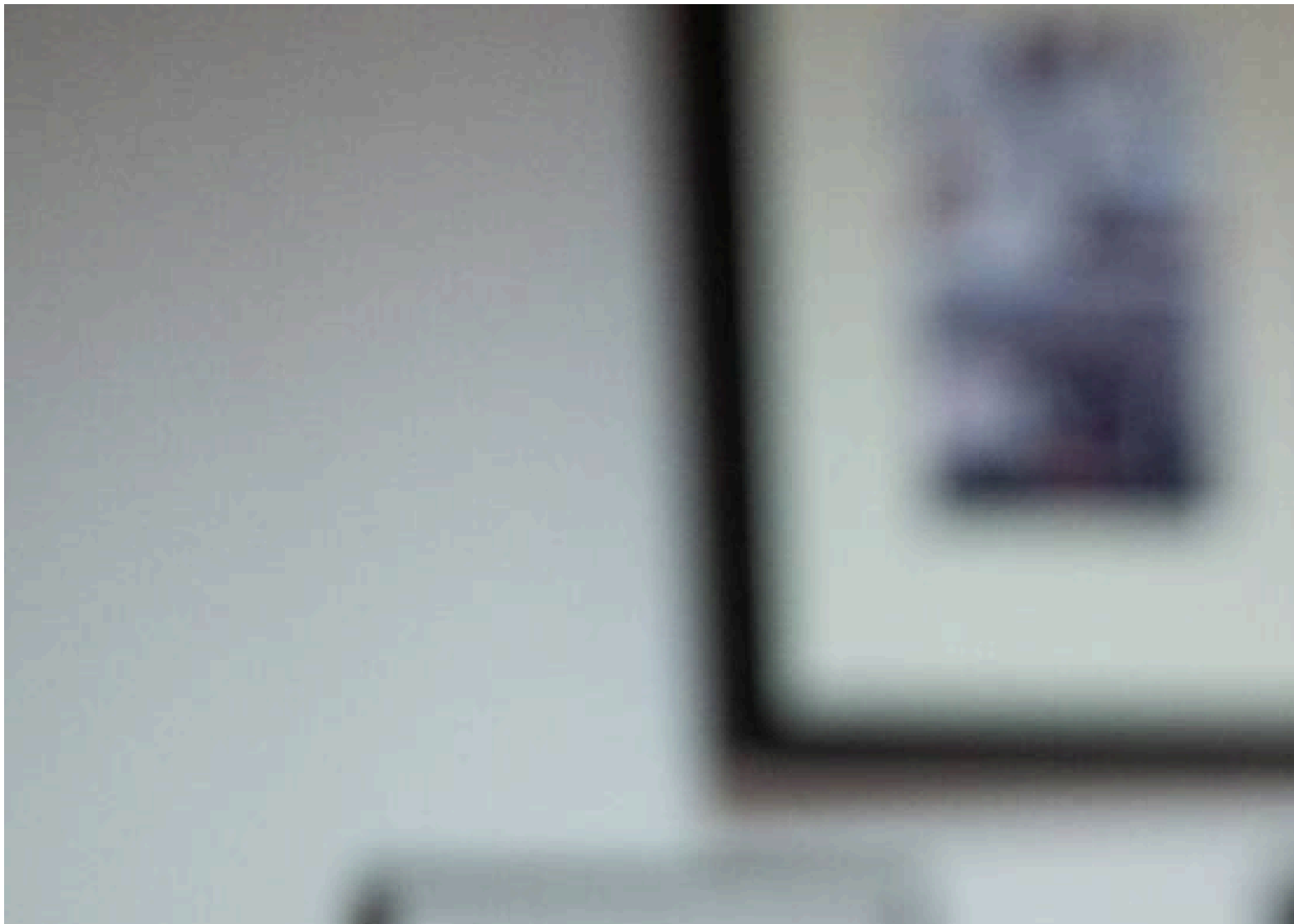
"The technology has fundamentally improved how officers patrol and how detectives investigate crimes spanning a range of serious offenses including robbery, kidnapping, carjacking, burglar

Why Newsom vetoed last year's bill

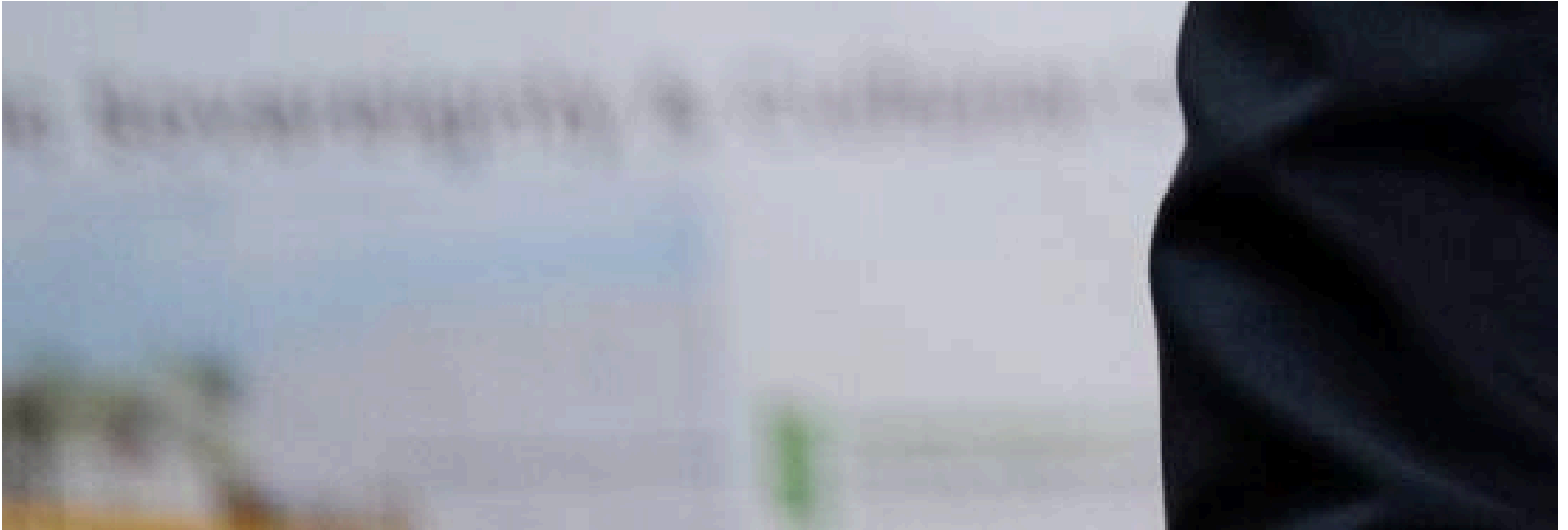
Such investigative success stories may have helped persuade Newsom to veto last year's bill, which would have required police to dump their license plate data within 60 days.

In his [veto message](#), he said the restrictions on sharing data and forcing departments to purge it could hinder officers' ability to solve cold cases and find missing people.

Newsom also said there was no money in the budget to pay for the mandatory California Department of Justice audits last year's bill would have required.







Gov. Gavin Newsom speaks during a press conference at the Friendship House Association of American Indians in San Francisco on Jan. 16, 2026. (Beth LaBerge/KQED)

To address Newsom’s concerns, this year’s proposal allows police to retain data to locate missing people and it makes a state audit program contingent on future funding.

Newsom’s press office declined to say whether he has a position on the latest bill, which has advanced through the Legislature with only Republicans voting against it.

The measure is now pending before the Assembly Appropriations Committee. Meanwhile, at least one Republican lawmaker is taking the issue to Congress.

RELATED ARTICLE

'Get The Flock Out': The Fight Over License-Plate Readers

U.S. Rep. Thomas Massie of Kentucky recently shared a meme of a “Don’t Tread on Me” snake wrapped around a camera. The riff on the yellow Gadsden flag says, “Don’t Flock me.”

“I’ll soon be sponsoring a bill to withhold federal money from municipalities and police departments that deploy Flock (and other style) cameras to surveil law-abiding citizens,” Massie [wrote](#) Rosenberg of Oakland Privacy said she understands the cameras’ usefulness to California police, but she thinks they’ve become ubiquitous.

Police, she said, also shouldn’t have a permanent pass to keep “mountains” of data for as long as they want.

“There is kind of a balancing act. We as human beings also need some camera-free space,” she said. “We don’t want to be on camera every minute of every single day.”

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